of this hall, through an archway, we could see our new living room, and amazingly, our furniture from California was already there, welcoming us with a warm familiarity; it was the first example of the kind of minor miracle we later came to take for granted from the White House staff.

I think it was only then, as Nancy and I walked hand in hand down the great Central Hall, that it hit home that I was president. We'd had the election, the election-night parties, the weeks of planning for my administration, the hours spent choosing a cabinet, then the pomp of the inaugural ceremony. But it was only at this moment that I appreciated the enormity of what had happened to me.

Maybe it was just recognizing our own furniture in the White House that did it. Maybe it had something to do with being reminded of my childhood by the Dixon High marching band. The depth of the emotion we felt at that moment is hard to describe. It packed a wallop that made both of us misty-eyed.

For so long, I had shared the reverence most Americans have for that historic building; back when I was a kid in Dixon, I'd imagined what the private part of the White House must be like; but I had never imagined myself actually living there. Now, we had gone in the front door, gotten on an elevator, and we were here to stay—at least for four years.

If I could do this, I thought, then truly any child in America had an opportunity to do it.

Still walking hand in hand, Nancy and I examined the rooms on the second floor that were to be our new home. We could almost feel the presence of those who had lived here before—Roosevelt, Truman, Eisenhower, Wilson, and others, especially Lincoln, whose bedroom was furnished exactly as it had been during the period when he lived in the White House. In it was a large, oversize wooden bedstead that Lincoln's wife, Mary, was having made for her